UPFRONT

HEALTHWATCH: THE HANTAVIRUS SCARE *PG 11*

GRAPHIC: THE BIG SHIFT IN CRIME *PG 12*



ATUL KUMAR YADAV

RISING FURY
Students protest the NEET paper leak in New Delhi, May 13

▶ NEET PAPER LEAK

WARNINGS IGNORED

Despite two committees prescribing reforms, NEET (UG) collapsed again because the National Testing Agency adopted visible safeguards while ignoring structural fixes

By KAUSHIK DEKA

ON MAY 12, THE NATIONAL TESTING AGENCY (NTA) cancelled the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET (UG), conducted nine days earlier for more than 2.2 million medical aspirants. It was the first outright cancellation in the test's history and arrived after the agency had spent two years promising it had been reformed. The exam will be held again.

But the country has not stumbled into the same disaster twice by accident. It has produced an executive culture in which the recommendations meant to prevent it can be selectively adopted or politely ignored. Two high-powered committees have already written the autopsy.

The first was the High-Level Committee of Experts, chaired by Dr K. Radhakrishnan, former ISRO chairman, constituted by the Union ministry of education on June 22, 2024, after the NEET (UG) paper leaks. Its mandate, widened by the Supreme Court that August, ran the full length of the examination chain. The committee submitted its report on October 21, 2024, with 101 recommendations. The ministry made it public only